

TRUSTMRR · 1,000 VERIFIED STARTUPS

The AI gold rush is real. The *money* isn't there.

197 of 1,000 startups are AI — by far the biggest category. Rank them by revenue and AI lands 8th. An investment thesis, told in six charts.

197

AI startups tracked

8th

AI's rank by median revenue

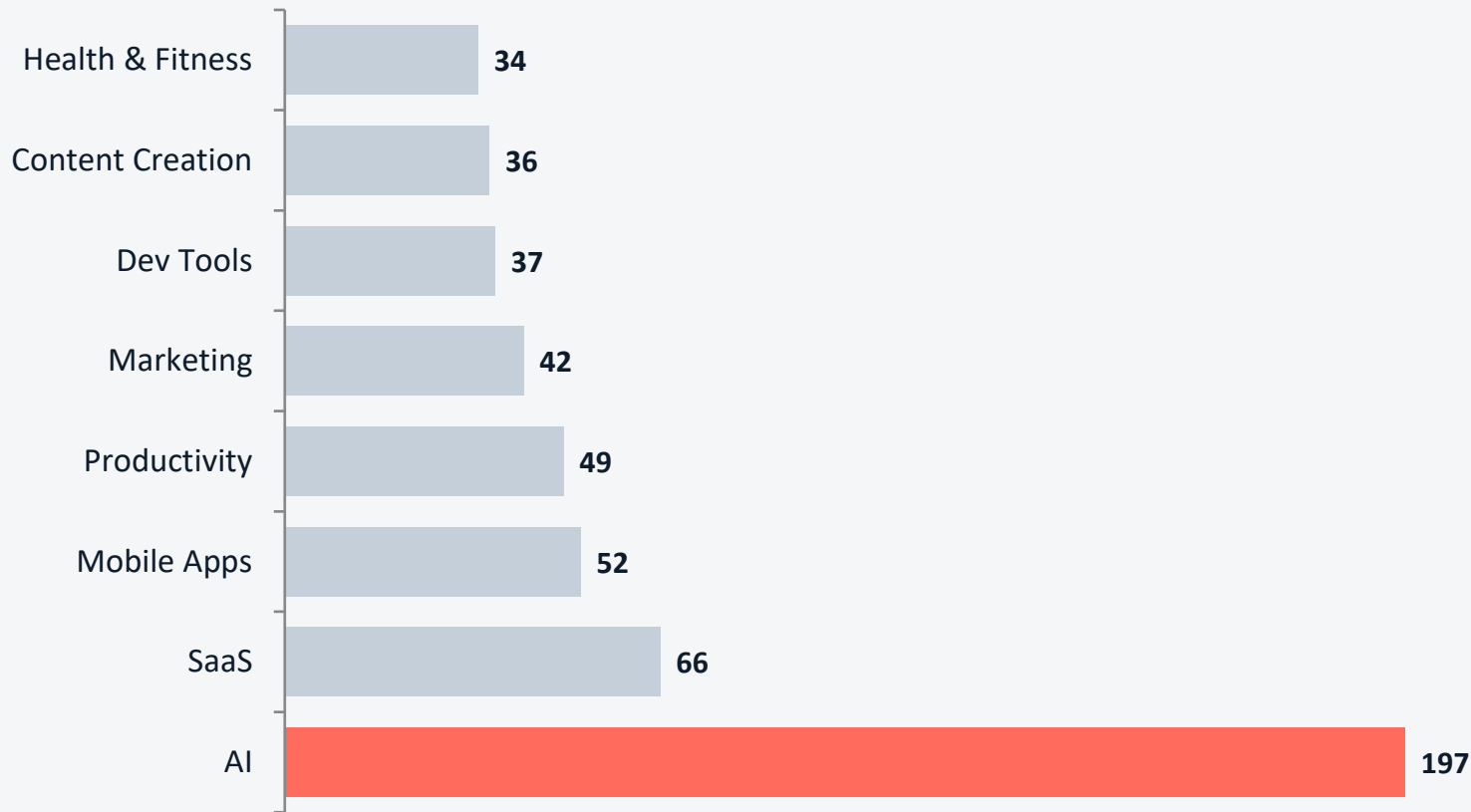
\$503

AI median monthly rev

THE CROWD

Everyone is building the same thing

AI is nearly 1 in 5 startups on the leaderboard — 3× the next-biggest category.



197

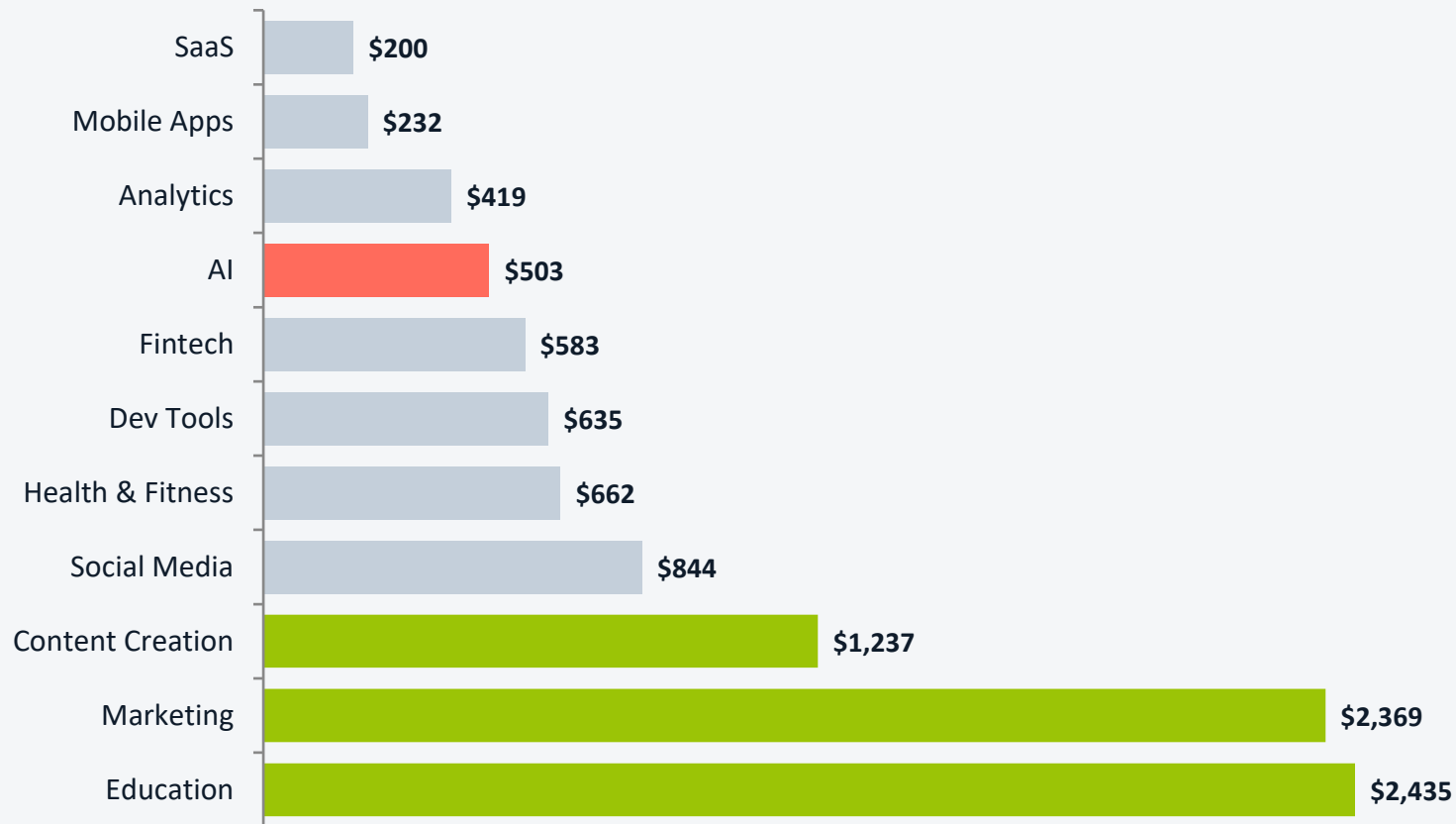
AI startups

More than SaaS, Mobile & Productivity
combined.

THE TWIST

...but the crowd isn't getting paid

Median monthly revenue by category. The biggest category earns less than "boring" ones half its size.



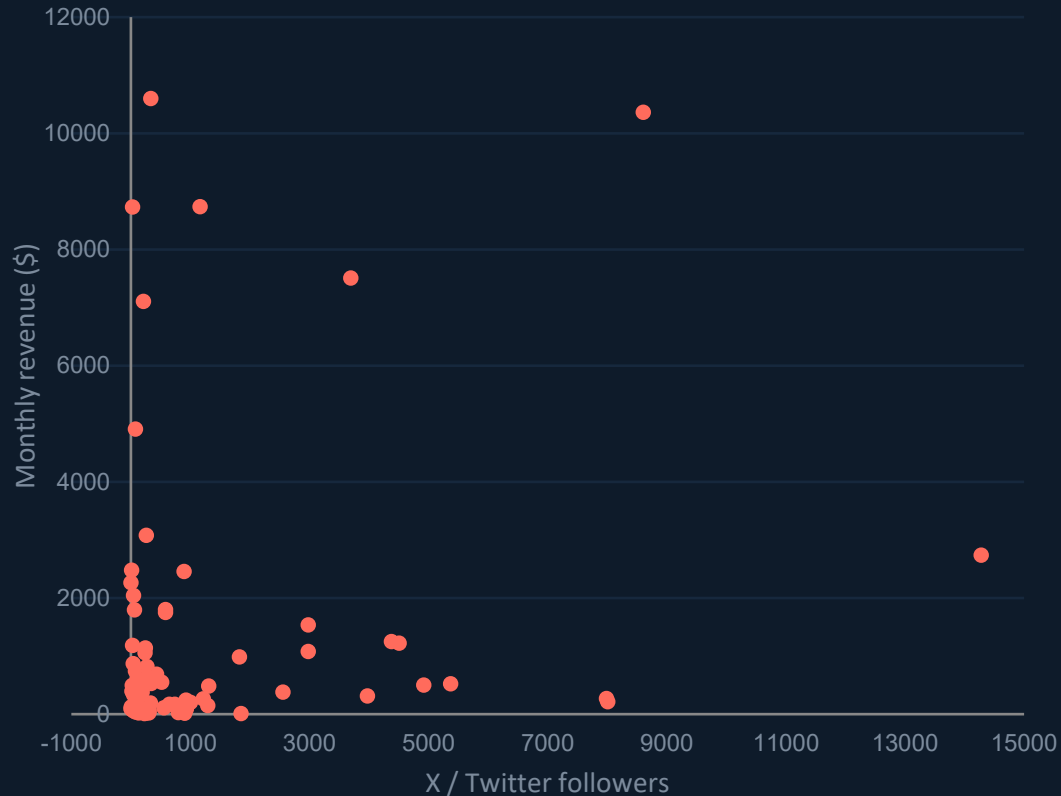
3.5x

Education, Marketing & Content out-earn AI on median revenue

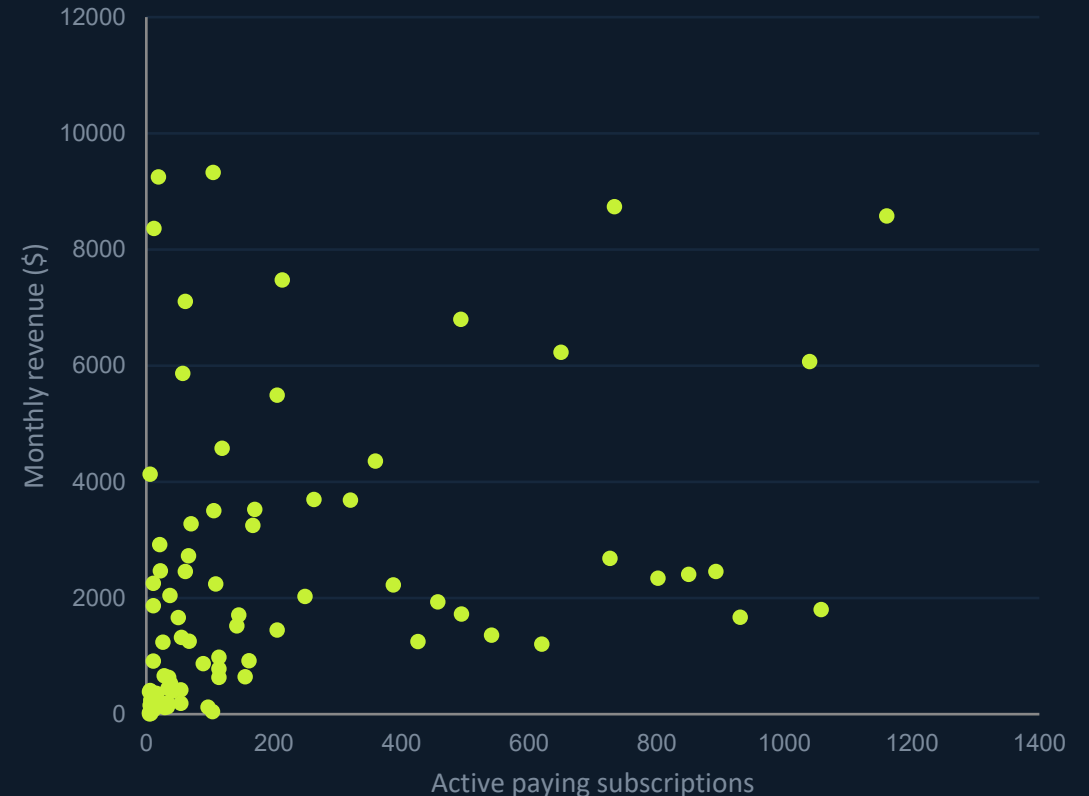
AI is 8th. Everyone's building it. Few are getting paid for it.

WHERE REVENUE ACTUALLY COMES FROM

Followers don't pay bills. *Customers do.*



$r = 0.02$ no relationship

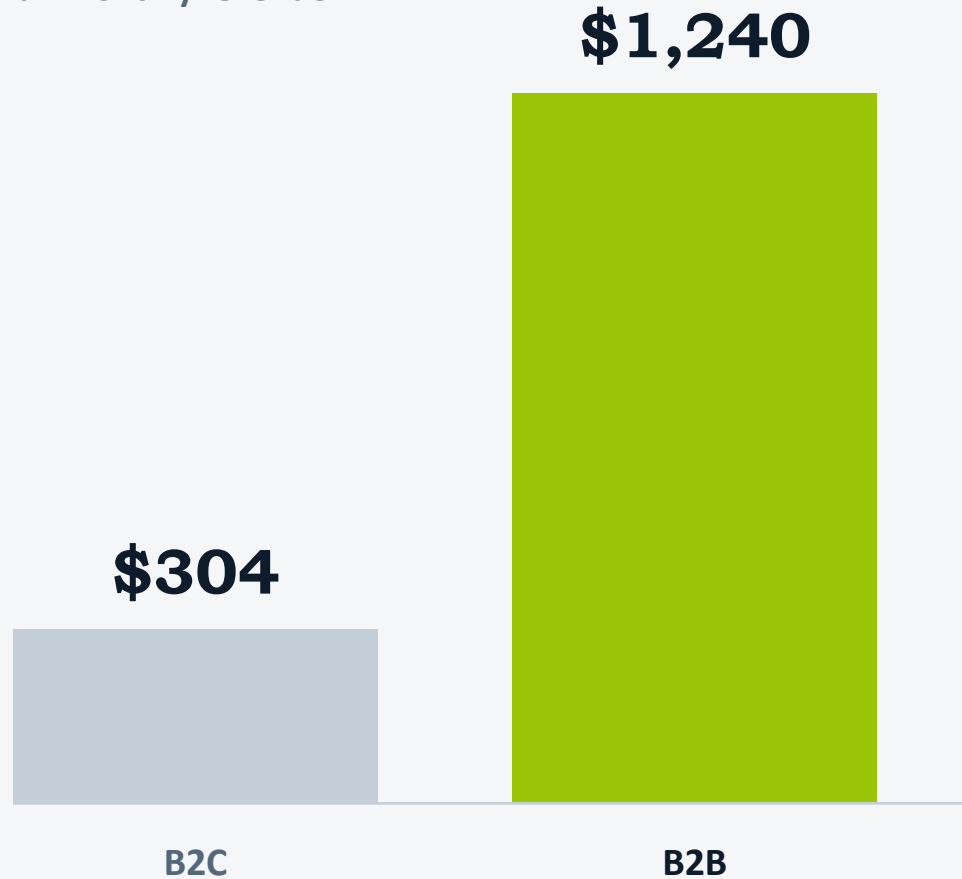


$r = 0.80$ strong relationship

WHO PAYS, AND HOW MUCH

Businesses pay invoices. Consumers don't.

Median monthly revenue



4.1× more revenue, same effort

The AI Gold Rush · TrustMRR 1,000-startup dataset

The winner-takes-all reality

73%

of all revenue is captured by the top 5% of startups

58%

of startups earn under \$1,000 a month

\$399

median monthly revenue across all 1,000

THE INVESTMENT THESIS

Don't invest because it's AI. Invest where customers *already* *pay.*

1

Skip the crowd

197 AI startups compete on hype. The median one makes \$503/mo.

2

Follow the money

"Boring" categories — Education, Marketing, Content — out-earn AI 3.5×.

3

Count customers, not clout

Followers→revenue: $r=0.02$. Subscriptions→revenue: $r=0.80$.

4

Back B2B

Businesses pay 4.1× more than consumers, for the same build.